

SONOMA COUNTY GAZETTE

Declining tasting room visits have Sonoma wineries fighting back



Sonoma County Winegrowers

Vines flourish in Sonoma County's Knight's Valley AVA, where local grape growers and vintners explore collaborative efforts to boost wine marketing and tourism. (Sonoma County Winegrowers)

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Sonoma County wine producers, facing declining sales, shifting consumer tastes, and climate pressures, are now considering a county-wide Wine Improvement District (WID) to fund collective marketing and tourism outreach. If approved, this plan would mark the first time Sonoma wineries collectively assess themselves to boost their shared business interests.

The proposal emerged in July through a partnership between Sonoma County Winegrowers (SCW) and Sonoma County Vintners (SCV), the leading industry organizations representing grape growers and wineries. Both groups have long promoted Sonoma wines separately. Now, faced with stark economic realities, they are joining forces.

“The challenges we face demand coordinated action,” said Prema Kerollis, SCV board chair and co-founder of Three Sticks Wines. Kerollis leads the WID steering committee alongside Steve Sangiacomo, a prominent third-generation grape grower. Their goal is clear: to restore growth in wine sales and tasting-room traffic.

The proposed district would function similarly to existing tourism improvement districts. Sonoma County hotels have successfully funded regional tourism marketing this way since 2005. Under the WID, wineries would pay a modest, mandatory assessment — likely around 1% of direct-to-consumer sales — to finance marketing campaigns. Those funds would specifically target wine tourists and premium wine buyers, crucial audiences that individual wineries often struggle to reach on their own.

Direct-to-consumer sales, primarily through tasting rooms, have recently slowed significantly. According to SCV figures, Sonoma County tasting-room visits dropped 14% in 2024 and another 8.4% in early 2025. Those declines hurt smaller, family-owned wineries the most, as many depend heavily on direct sales.

“Reversing that trend is critical,” explained Karissa Kruse, president of SCW. “We’re seeing the effects of changing consumer preferences. Younger drinkers are shifting toward craft beer, spirits, and even non-alcoholic beverages. To attract these customers, wineries need stronger collective marketing.”

This collective effort would also amplify existing messaging around Sonoma County’s sustainability leadership. Currently, 99% of local vineyards are certified sustainable — the highest rate nationally. Kruse sees the WID as a strategic way to highlight sustainability practices that resonate with consumers seeking authenticity.

Another pressing concern is climate change, especially the region’s recent history of wildfires and drought. The 2020 wildfires alone resulted in \$150 million in losses from grapes that were left unharvested. To adapt, growers are diversifying grape varieties, and wineries are piloting projects to cut greenhouse gases. WID-funded marketing could spotlight these innovations, positioning Sonoma as a leader in climate-smart winegrowing.

Beyond immediate economic gains, the WID addresses longer-term challenges. Generational turnover among vineyard owners poses a real threat, with many retiring without clear successors. SCW and SCV are developing initiatives to support younger and diverse farmers, maintaining the region’s agricultural heritage. According to SCW, more than 80% of vineyard jobs are now year-round positions rather than seasonal, reflecting a commitment to workforce stability.

Next steps for the WID involve detailed discussions among local wineries, followed by a formal petition and a weighted vote of all affected wineries. Under California law, at least 51% approval — weighted by sales volume — is required to establish the district. Final authorization would come from the Sonoma County Board of Supervisors.

The WID would be governed by an industry-controlled nonprofit board, separate from government, ensuring that marketing dollars stay focused solely on wineries' needs.

While some winery owners remain cautious about mandatory fees, early feedback from industry stakeholders is positive. Many see the WID as essential to maintaining Sonoma's competitive edge against other wine regions that already use similar district models successfully, such as Santa Barbara and Temecula.

"This is about preserving Sonoma County's identity," Kerollis emphasized. "Our wineries and grape growers share a common future. We need to invest together if we're going to thrive."

The proposed WID, if adopted, could launch within a year or two, reshaping how Sonoma County promotes its iconic wines for years to come.